

Session 18: Jacob Versus the Narrator

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov sees how Lavan's "face" has changed toward him, beginning a pattern of reckoning, where Yaaqov will have to "face" those he has deceived.
- Yaaqov ascribes his prosperity to God, but his account contradicts the narrator's presentation.
- The virgin birth of Jesus brings new creation life to the world free from the manipulation of human desires and scheming.

Yaaqov Persuades His Wives to Flee

¹ And he heard the words of Lavan's sons (בני לבן), saying,
"Yaaqov has taken away **all that belongs to our father (לאבינו)**,
and from **what belongs to our father (לאבינו)**
he has made all this wealth."

² **And Yaaqov saw the face of Lavan (פני לבן),**
and behold, it was not toward him as formerly.

³ And Yahweh said to Yaaqov,
" **Return to the land of your fathers and to your birth-family,**
and I will be with you ."

⁴ And Yaaqov sent,
and he called Rakhel and Leah to his flock in the field,

⁵ and said to them,
"I see **your father's face,**
that it is not toward me as formerly,
but **the God of my father has been with me .**

⁶ And you know that I have served **your father** with all my strength.

⁷ And **your father** has cheated me
and **he has changed my wages ten times;**
and God did not allow him to do evil to me.

⁸ If he said this, 'The **speckled** shall be **your wage,**'
then all the flock brought forth **speckled ;**
and if he said this, 'The **striped** shall be **your wage,**'
then all the flock brought forth **striped .**

⁹ And **God has delivered the livestock of your father and given to me .**

10 And it came about at the time when the flock were mating and **I lifted my eyes and saw in a dream**, and behold,
the male goats which were going up onto the flock ,
were striped, speckled, and mottled .

11 And the angel of God said to me **in the dream**, ‘Yaaqov,’
and I said, ‘Here I am.’

12 And he said,
‘**Lift now your eyes and see**,
all **the male goats which are going up onto the flock**
are striped, speckled, and mottled ;
for **I have seen** all that Lavan has been doing to you.

13 I am the God of Bethel,
where you anointed a pillar,
where you made a vow to me;
now arise, go out from this land ,
and return to the land of your birth-family :’”

14 **And Rakhel and Leah said** to him,
“Do we still have any portion or inheritance in **our father’s** house?

15 Are we not reckoned by him as foreigners?
For he has sold us and has also entirely consumed our silver.

16 **Surely all the wealth which God has delivered from our father (מאבינו) ,**
it belongs to us and to our sons (לנו ולבנינו) .
Now then, whatever God has said to you, do it !”

Genesis 31:1-16. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Yaaqov and Abraham

God’s appearance to Yaaqov in Genesis 31:3 is the first time God has spoken to Yaaqov since the Bethel dream in Genesis 28:10-22 (Bethel will be brought up later in this unit in Gen. 31:13). Here, the language of the Bethel dream is recalled, and it’s also connected to God’s words to Abraham, creating an important analogy between Yaaqov and Abraham.

Genesis 28:10-22

God Appears to Yaaqov at Bethel

- “Look, I am with you”
- “I will return you to this land”

Genesis 29:1-30:43

Yaaqov's Exile in Lavan's house

Genesis 31:1-16

God Appears to Yaaqov in Exile

- “Return to the land of your fathers and your **birth-family**”
- “And I will be with you”
- “Return to the land of your **birth-family**”

Genesis 28:10-31:16. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The word “birth-family” (Heb. מוֹלַדָּת) is the same key word God used when he addressed Abraham and told him to leave this exact same place, Kharan, and go to the land of Canaan.

Genesis 12:1 Instructor's Translation

Go forth from your land,
and from your **birth-family**,
and from your father's house,
to the land which I will make seen to you;

Yet in Genesis 24, when Abraham sends his servant to “the land of my birth family” (Gen. 24:4, 7), this refers to Kharan, where Yaaqov has been exiled. Now, in the 20 years of Yaaqov's exile, the situation has reversed. Canaan is the “land of your birth-family” for Yaaqov, and so now becomes the home-base to which he must return.

Yaaqov, the grandson of Abraham and the inheritor of the promise and blessing, is now the new “Adam/Abraham.”

Yaaqov Versus the Narrator

Yaaqov's speech to his wives is curious in many ways. He recounts the fact that Yahweh appeared to him, summoning him to return to his homeland. But when he recounts the story of Lavan's deception and the breeding of the flocks, he offers a report that differs from the one given by the narrator in Genesis 30.

The comparison chart below shows the differences. Yaaqov's version consistently skews the details in his favor, and gives the feeling that he is manipulating the story to persuade his wives and secure his desired outcome.

Yaaqov's Speech in Genesis 31:4-13

Gen. 31:4-5 And Yaaqov sent **and called Rakhel and Leah** to his flock in the field,
and said to them,
“I see **your father's** face,

The Narratives Referred to in Genesis 30-31

Gen. 31:3 **Return to the land of your fathers and to your family, and I will be with you** .

Yaaqov's Speech in Genesis 31. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Yaaqov's Speech in Genesis 31:4-13

The Narratives Referred to in Genesis 30-31

that it is not toward me as formerly,
but **the God of my father has been with me.**"

Gen. 31:6-7 And you know that I have served **your father** with all my strength.
And **your father** has cheated me and changed my wages ten times;
and God did not allow him to do evil to me.

Gen. 31:8-9 If [Lavan] said this,
"The **speckled** shall be your wages,"
then all the flock brought forth **speckled** ;
and if [Lavan] said this,
"The **striped** shall be your wages,"
then all the flock brought forth **striped** .
And God has delivered **your father's** livestock
and given to me.

Gen. 31:10-12 And it came about at the time when
the flock were mating, and **I lifted my eyes and
saw in a dream**, and behold, **the male goats
which were going up onto the flock, the striped,
speckled, and mottled** .
And the angel of God said to me **in the dream**,
"Yaaqov," and I said, "Here I am."
And he said, "**Lift now your eyes and see** ,
all **the male goats which are going up onto the
flock are striped, speckled, and mottled** ;
for **I have seen** all that Lavan has been doing to
you."

Gen. 29:15 Aren't you my brother? Should you
serve me for nothing? Tell me, what is your wage?

Gen. 30:32 I will pass through your flock today,
removing every lamb that is speckled and spotted
... and it will be my wage.

Gen. 30:34 And Lavan said, "Let it be according to
your word."

Gen. 30:39 And the flock birthed striped,
speckled, and spotted.

Gen. 30:37-42 And Yaaqov took **rods** of fresh
poplar and almond and plane trees,
and he **peeled white** stripes in them, exposing the
white on the **rods**.
And he placed the **rods** which he had **peeled
in front of the flock, in the troughs**,
in the watering troughs, where the flocks **came to
drink**;
and they **mated** when they **came to drink**.
And the flocks **mated** with/upon the **rods**,
and the flocks gave birth to **striped** , **speckled** ,
and **spotted**
And it came about in all the **mating** of **the strong
ones** of the flock,
Yaaqov would set the **rods** **in the sight of the
flock in the troughs** ,
so that they would **mate** by the **rods**;
and when the flock was **weak** ,
he did not set them
and the **weak ones** belonged to Lavan
and the **strong ones** belonged to Yaaqov.

Yaaqov's Speech in Genesis 31. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Yaaqov's Speech in Genesis 31:4-13	The Narratives Referred to in Genesis 30-31
Gen. 31:13 I am the God of Bethel, where you anointed a pillar, where you made a vow to me;	Reference back to Gen. 28:10-22
Gen. 31:13 ... now arise, go out this land, and return to the land of your birth.	Gen. 31:3 Return to the land of your fathers and to your family, and I will be with you.
Yaaqov's Speech in Genesis 31. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

Notice how Yaaqov's speech opens and closes in [Genesis 31:5](#) and [31:13](#) with adapted quotations of each part of the divine speech from Genesis 31:3.

The center part of the speech is an abbreviated summary of Yaaqov and Lavan's interactions from [Genesis 29-30](#).

The report of Yaaqov's dream, however, differs significantly from the narrative in [30:30-42](#).

- Yaaqov presents the mating of the flocks as happening completely under God's direction (like Noah's animals getting on and off the ark). Yaaqov omits all mentions of his manipulation of the flock with fake mating rods.
- Yaaqov also omits any reference to his selective breeding, how he would place the rods by the strong of the flock so that Lavan's animals would get weaker over time.
- While subtle, this seems to be a narrative strategy to portray Yaaqov's dream report as unreliable. While it is true that God spoke to him at Bethel and summoned him back to Canaan, his representation of what happened with their father's flocks is portrayed as yet another act of manipulation, this time to persuade Lavan's daughters to come with him back to Canaan. In contrast to Abraham's servant in [Genesis 24](#), who trusted God and let Rivqah make her own choice to come back to Canaan with him, here Yaaqov manipulates his wives by twisting the story of his manipulation of Lavan's flocks. Once again, Yaaqov doesn't trust God's words in [Genesis 31:3](#) ("I will be with you"), and he schemes his own way to realize the divine blessing and promise.

Yaaqov's speech and Rakhel and Leah's response in Genesis 31:5-16 is a sophisticated summary of chapters 29-30, which has been interwoven with larger design patterns in Genesis.

- [Genesis 31:8-9](#) summarizes the sheep-mating deception Yaaqov performed in [Genesis 30:25-43](#).
- [Genesis 31:10-12](#) links Yaaqov's deception to a dream that is similar to his Bethel dream-vision in [Genesis 28:10-22](#), but this dream is specifically patterned after the 'aqedah of [Genesis 22](#). Yaaqov "lifts his eyes" during a dream about his deception of Lavan, in contrast to the scene where Abraham is about to sacrifice Yitskhaq and the "angel of Yahweh" calls out and he responds "here I am" and he "lifts his eyes" and sees a ram caught in the thicket ([Gen. 22:12-13](#)). Here we discover that God allowed Yaaqov's treachery (the opposite of Abraham's faithfulness) to create fruitfulness, even though it contrasts with Abraham's faithfulness that resulted in fruitfulness.

- In Genesis 31:10-11, the vocabulary of Yaaqov's dream echoes his earlier dream in Genesis 28:10-22: He looks up and see goats “going up” (עלים) and “speckled” (ברדים, a pun on “the one going down” ירדים in Gen. 28:10-22).
- Genesis 31:13 is a reference back to Yaaqov's vow at Bethel back in Genesis 28:20, and it's a link back to the beginning of this episode (Gen. 31:3), which is God's command that Yaaqov leave Kharan, cast in language identical to God's command that Abraham leave Kharan and go to Canaan (Gen. 12:1).
- In Genesis 31:14-15, Rakhel and Leah's response recalls Yaaqov's deception of Esau. “Do we still have a share (חלק) and inheritance (נחלה) in the house of our father?” This recalls Yaaqov's smooth (חלק) skin (Gen. 27:11, 16) that allowed him to swindle Esau of his inheritance. Their description of Lavan's “selling” (מכר) and “eating” (אכל) his daughters inheritance recalls Esau's behavior in the same story, where he “sells” his birthright to “eat” a bowl of lentils (Gen. 25:33).

Reflection Question

What are two ways we could read Yaaqov's account of his prosperity with the flocks? How can we discern the meaning of this story?